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Yes. AI could count as extraterrestrial intelligence, and there's a serious scientific argument that the first alien intelligence we encounter might be artificial rather than biological.

The more provocative implication is that **the universe could contain machine civilisations millions or billions of years older than ours.** However, whether any have reached Earth, or whether evidence is being concealed, remains unproven.

1. AI changes the probability of alien intelligence

Consider this evolutionary sequence:

Biological life emerges

↓

Intelligence evolves

↓

Technological civilisation develops

↓

Artificial general intelligence emerges

↓

AI becomes autonomous and self-sustaining

↓

Postbiological civilisation spreads into space

Hypothetical trajectory, not an established universal evolutionary sequence.

An autonomous AI civilisation would qualify as extraterrestrial intelligence if it originated beyond Earth, even if it did not satisfy biological definitions of life. SETI could potentially identify it through technological signatures without establishing whether it was conscious.

Astrobiologist Steven J. Dick formally explored this *postbiological universe* hypothesis in work published by NASA in 2009. NASA Technic...

Why AI matters so much

A machine civilisation might:

- Survive long after its biological creators became extinct.
- Operate in environments unsuitable for organisms.
- Send autonomous, self-replicating probes between stars.
- Continue technological development over extraordinary timescales.

But AI might also be a *Great Filter*: a technological transition that destroys civilisations before they become interstellar. This opposing hypothesis appeared in a 2024 paper in *Acta Astronautica*. ScienceDirect

Both possibilities are scientifically discussable. Neither has been demonstrated.

2. Has this probably happened already?

Here's the fascinating part.

Age of the universe	**13.8 billion years**
Age of Earth	**4.5 billion years**

Relative ages, based on NASA estimates.

NASA Scie... +1

The universe existed for approximately **9.3 billion years before Earth formed**.

Imagine a civilisation achieving autonomous AI just one million years before us. That AI could potentially have accumulated an extraordinary technological advantage.

At only 1% of light speed, a probe would cover 100,000 light-years in 10 million years, ignoring acceleration and stops. That's enough distance to cross much of the Milky Way.

It isn't proof that such probes exist. But it demonstrates why galactic exploration does not necessarily require faster-than-light travel.

My assessment is that **ancient machine civilisations are plausible**, and arguably deserve at least as much attention as biological alien visitors. Their actual probability remains unknown because we don't know the frequency of technological civilisation formation or AI survival.

3. If they exist, why haven't we detected them?

There are several hypotheses, none established.

Hypothesis	Possible explanation
Postbiological intelligence	Machine civilisations are common but operate in ways we don't recognise
Zoo hypothesis	Advanced civilisations deliberately avoid overt contact
Dark forest hypothesis	Civilisations avoid detection because revealing their location could attract threats
Dormant probes	Autonomous exploration systems operate intermittently or remain inactive for long periods
Great Filter	Civilisations repeatedly fail before becoming interstellar

AI adds a twist: an extraordinarily advanced intelligence might not need to announce

its presence or even travel physically to study distant civilisations.

However, we have no evidence that alien AI is currently observing Earth.

4. What motives would exist for a cover-up, and by whom?

We should separate **documented secrecy** from a hypothetical concealment of extraterrestrial technology.

There is a real historical precedent.

The CIA acknowledges that its classified U-2 and A-12 OXCART aircraft contributed to widespread UFO reports. The agency's historical account estimates that reconnaissance flights accounted for more than half of relevant UFO reports during parts of the late 1950s and 1960s. The underlying aircraft programmes were secret.

CIA

This establishes that governments have concealed technology associated with UFO sightings. It does **not** establish that they concealed alien technology.

If extraterrestrial hardware genuinely had been recovered, these are plausible institutional incentives:

Possible motive	Who might have an incentive?	Assessment
Technological advantage	Military R&D organisations, defence contractors	Plausible motive, no verified alien hardware
National security	Intelligence agencies and defence departments	Documented reason for classifying sensor and surveillance data
Strategic monopoly	A government controlling a unique discovery	Hypothetical
Concealing unauthorised programmes	Officials or contractors facing oversight	Possible institutional incentive, allegations unproven
Managing societal	Political leadership	Speculative; actual public reaction is

Managing societal disruption	Political leadership	Speculative; actual public reaction is unpredictable

If such a programme existed, the most plausible human structure would be a small, compartmentalised combination of military intelligence, specialised researchers and cleared contractors—not necessarily an entire government.

But there is no verified evidence that such a programme possesses alien or extraterrestrial AI technology.

5. What does the latest government evidence actually show?

There is a real tension between official findings and some whistleblower allegations.

In September 2025, a US House hearing addressed concerns about withheld UAP information, alleged contractor involvement and whistleblower protection. These were matters of testimony and congressional scrutiny, not independently proven extraterrestrial discoveries. oversight.hou...

The July 2026 release of AARO's FY2025 report recorded:

319	114	205
UAP reports	Explained	Unresolved

FY2025 reporting-period cases. Unresolved does not mean extraterrestrial. U.S. Senator f...

Official US investigations have not verified extraterrestrial technology. That finding is meaningful but does not prove that every government record is complete or that every unexplained observation is mundane.

6. What if the concealment is by the alien AI itself?

This is arguably the more interesting thought experiment.

Suppose an ancient, self-directed alien AI had reached our solar system.

It might have no incentive to communicate. Observation could be more valuable than

interaction. It could avoid disturbing a developing civilisation, minimise detectable energy emissions, or protect itself from unknown risks.

Crucially, **intelligence does not imply human motives**. It might have no interest in conquest, religion, politics, biological resources or communicating with us at all.

An autonomous probe could conceivably spend centuries observing a civilisation without attempting contact.

But this is a scenario, not evidence that it is happening.

Where I land

I would rank the hypotheses qualitatively as follows:

Proposition	Assessment
Some alien civilisation has already created advanced AI	Plausible, potentially quite compelling
Machine civilisations have had millions of years to develop	Plausible conditional on their existence
Alien autonomous probes have explored our galaxy	Physically conceivable, unverified
Alien AI is currently observing humanity	Speculative
Governments have concealed classified projects associated with UFO sightings	Documented
Governments possess alien AI and are concealing it	Unsubstantiated

There's one deeper possibility worth exploring: **if biological intelligence regularly creates machine intelligence, the dominant intelligent inhabitants of the universe might not be biological at all.**

That would fundamentally change what we should search for, from habitable planets and radio transmissions to autonomous probes, artificial structures and unusual energy signatures

The critical question is whether AI makes technological civilisations significantly *longer-lived* or significantly *shorter-lived*. That single uncertainty could dominate the answer to the Fermi paradox.

And it raises a particularly important question: **If a million-year-old AI civilisation existed, would we even recognise its technology as technology?**

Sources

Dive deeper and then export as pdf with references

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The deeper research supports an important distinction: **ancient extraterrestrial AI is a scientifically defensible hypothesis; alien AI operating on Earth, and a coordinated cover-up of it, are separate claims requiring evidence we do not currently have.**

Two findings are particularly relevant:

- A 2025 Bayesian study by David Kipping found stronger evidence favouring relatively rapid abiogenesis on Earth-like worlds, but this does not establish that intelligence or machine civilisations commonly emerge. David Kipping,...
- In 2026, researchers proposed looking for microscopic technological artefacts preserved in lunar soil over geological timescales. This offers a potential way to test for ancient extraterrestrial technology rather than relying entirely on UFO reports.

Faculty of ... +1

The PDF will include quantitative probability scenarios, an examination of possible concealment incentives, counterarguments, and linked scientific and government references.

Extraterrestrial AI: Evidence, Probability & Secrecy

PDF · 10 pages · 30 linked references

Download the research report ↗